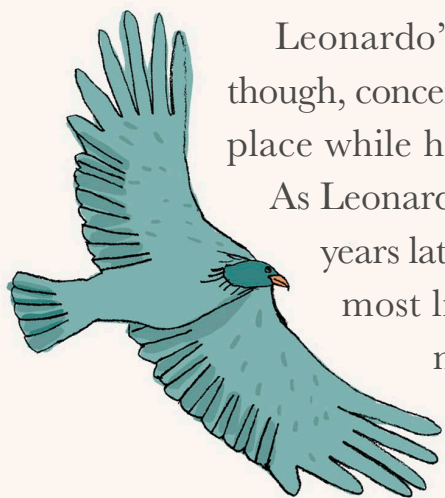




Leonardo's earliest memory, though, concerned an incident that took place while he was still in the cradle.

As Leonardo remembered it many years later, a large bird of prey—most likely a vulture—landed next to him. This in itself was not so remarkable, but what happened next was very strange indeed.

The vulture opened Leonardo's lips with its feathers, then used its tail to strike him several times inside the mouth.

Why did the vulture do such a thing? Leonardo had no idea, and of course the vulture couldn't explain its actions. So the whole episode remained a mystery.

Nobody knows if this really happened or not, but Leonardo himself believed that it did. Certainly, it would have been an odd tale to make up. In any case, it was the beginning of his lifelong fascination with birds.